

Issue, rule, analysis, conclusion

Lawyers are trained to think a problem through in four steps. You can use the same steps for any business problem, before you react.

REMEMBER

- ◆ Name the real issue first. Most arguments are about the wrong one.
- ◆ Find the rule that applies: the contract, the policy, the law, the agreement you made.
- ◆ Argue the other side to yourself before you decide.

YOUR TURN

The situation I am facing:

Issue: the actual question to be answered:

Rule: what the contract, policy or law says (or who I need to ask):

Analysis: how the rule applies to these facts, and how the other side would see it:

Conclusion: what I will do:

THIS WEEK

Take one open problem, such as a late payment or a client asking for more than you agreed, and write it out in the four steps before you respond.

Inspired by Adam Lange, "Think Like a Lawyer" (TEDx). General education, not legal advice.